

Rome connects a global community during Jubilee

By Kaya Equevilley



American travel writer and television host, Rick Steves films a segment of his television show on Europe in Rome on March 21. Steves references Rome as a city he has traveled to since he was a child. To Steves, a kind traveler means to “speak softly.”

As millions of tourists and pilgrims travel to Rome in 2025, with the potential to create challenges for locals, is there a “right” way to be a tourist? Locals and travel industry experts have recommendations.

More than 35 million pilgrims are expected to travel to Rome this year, according to The Vatican News. By comparison, in 2023, about 13 million travelers came to the city according to AFAR, a travel media brand.

“It’s difficult to answer [what it means to be a respectful tourist], basically you should be polite, always, and to everyone,” said Luca de Ponpeis.

De Ponpeis is a worker at an Italian suit shop in the heart of Rome. Growing up in Rome, de Ponpeis has seen many tourists.

Locals and travel industry experts recommend several ways for travelers to show respect as they travel in Rome during Jubilee. These include being polite toward others, being mindful of your surroundings, doing research about what you are traveling to see, and being patient, especially when cultural differences arise.

This year is known as the Jubilee, or the Holy Year, and has been a tradition for the Catholic faith since the year 1300. The Jubilee tradition, which occurs every 25 years, is an open invitation for individuals all around the world to visit the Vatican, a custom started by Pope Boniface VII.

The next Jubilee will be held in 2050.

A major event during Jubilee is the opening of the Holy Doors in St. Peter's Basilica, in the Vatican City.

"The Vatican gets an average of 35,000 visitors a day," said Paola Fontana, a tour guide for LivTours in Rome.

During recent years, the Jubilee year has held a theme. This year Pope Francis declared the theme as "Pilgrims of Hope."

Preparation for the Jubilee year has been ongoing for past year preceding the event. The city of Rome received \$2 billion from the Italian government specifically for the Jubilee with an additional \$3 billion in funds from the EU, all for the purpose of beautifying the city according to CNN.

Each year there are approximately 21 million tourists that visit the city according to the New York Post.

Rome's 2025 population is now estimated at 4,331,970 according to the world population review.

You need to know the history of a place you are traveling to in order to bring context to it, said Rick Steves, an American travel writer and television host.

"Understand what you are looking at [as a tourist] and bring context to it," said Steves.

The best way to be a respectful tourist is to be curious, everywhere you go. Even if you think the rules are stupid, be respectful, Fontana said. “Just be astonished by the beauty, be curious.”

“Tourists are not always respectful, with leaving things [trash] in places, on benches and I say ‘why?,’” Fontana said.

Overall Fontana has had a good experience with tourists, and said they are usually kind, even during busy tourist seasons.

“I hope there are only a few that are not respectful,” Fontana said.

Some of the ways to be respectful in Rome during Jubilee include cleaning up after yourself and speaking at a level that shows respect to the people you are around, some locals said.

The best way to be a kind traveler anywhere, but especially Rome is to “speak softly,” Steves said.

“Especially during Jubilee, I think respect [for tourists] looks like understanding that people are living a normal everyday life here, and you can’t just take over, have fun but I also wish people would remember that,” said Marisle Compton, a student at Sapienza University of Rome.

This is Compton’s first year experiencing Jubilee, though she has lived in Rome her entire life, and she expects to see an increase in tourism activity as well as the number of visitors in Rome this year.

“I think more often than not people have been respectful, they clean up after themselves, and they treat others with respect, but there are the people who don’t,” Compton said.

Having the opportunity to travel to other countries and other cities helps to keep an open mind as to what it means to be kind in a new place, said de Ponpeis. “I get to know different cultures because of tourism,” he said.

“I think that we need more education about the changes that tourists can bring,” de Ponpeis said.

“Being a kind traveler means respecting a culture and being patient,” said Christine Travers. Travers is in Rome with her husband and daughter for 10 days from Massachusetts. Travers chose Rome to visit because she wanted to learn more about the history, specifically during Jubilee.

“I’ve had to learn how to adapt to different cultural norms,” said Abby Travers.

Abby Travers, Christine Travers' daughter, is studying at the Lorenzo de' Medici Institute in Florence. The family thought this provided a good opportunity to visit Rome and The Vatican.

Going to school in another country is hard but exciting, and when you travel even within that country you learn new things, said Travers.